

MOTHERBOARDS

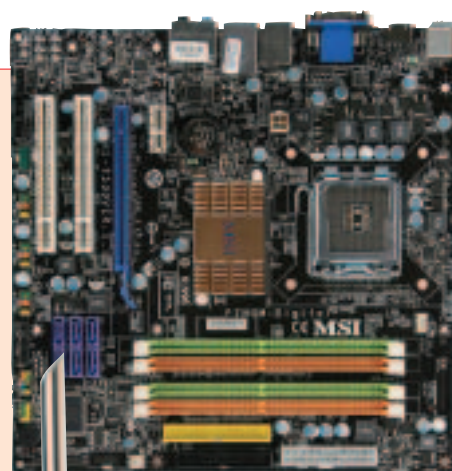
The yearly motherboard comparison tests are one of the most important categories of hardware tested. The last test was conducted for the November 2008 issue just after the new chipset releases over the past months. Motherboards with integrated graphics solutions in this test and another test for motherboards with no integrated graphics shall be coming up in the January 2009 issue. The motherboards had to split up into two big groups for the two platforms – Intel and AMD. As this test was conducted just a month ago, there are obviously no “Contenders” for any of the categories.

Motherboards For Intel Processors

REIGNING CHAMPION

ZOTAC GeForce 9300

The ZOTAC GeForce 9300 was our winner for the Best Buy mainly for its price. It performed very close to the MSI P7NGM Digital. It didn't have the same build quality as the MSI board, but it was a good Rs 700 cheaper as well. There were no big compromises either – this is a board that comes with a fan for the chipset, which is a GeForce 9300 board that can hold up 16 GB of DDR2 RAM. With the same performance and features at a cheaper price, it makes excellent sense. For people who want a cheap HTPC solution based on an Intel system, this motherboard is the one to buy.



Motherboards For Intel processors

BEST PERFORMER

MSI P7NGM DIGITAL

There were plenty of new chipset releases for the Intel platform. The most number of updates came from Intel and manufacturers were

quick to make new boards. Some of the new graphics chipsets from Intel were G43 and the G45. The other big lot of chipsets were developed by NVIDIA and the latest being the GeForce 9300 series for Intel processors.

The MSI P7NGM DIGITAL was one such motherboard that clearly had the edge over its competition. The only problem with this GeForce 9300 like the others was the inability to overclock. The BIOS lacked decent overclocking features and the northbridge also already runs too hot to overclock. As a solution, it makes excellent sense. The MSI P7NGM is without doubt the best onboard graphics solution that you can find for the Intel platform. All the necessary features were present and the performance in desktop applications benchmarks in general was also good. Games ran a lot faster than the Intel-based boards but more or less the same as the other GeForce 9300 boards that we tested.

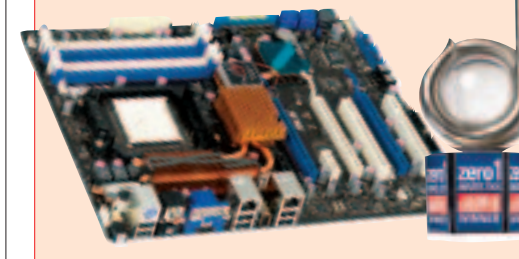
Even though this was one the first GeForce 9300 boards to come out in the market, it's still designed pretty well and also one of the few GeForce 9300 ones to be built with solid state capacitors. The price tag of Rs 5,500 was definitely a little expensive as compared as compared to the other boards but it made a well worth purchase anyway.

Motherboards For AMD

BEST PERFORMER

ASUS Crosshair II Formula

The ASUS Crosshair II Formula is the perfect performance board for enthusiasts. It gets the award for Best performer in the category for motherboards for the AMD platform. The board was based on the nForce 780a SLI chipset. The Crosshair II Formula performed exactly the same as the other ASUS board – M3N-HT Deluxe. The Crosshair II Formula came with two gigabit network ports. The package even contained the game *Company of Heroes - Opposing Fronts* and an LED poster. Priced at Rs 15,450, it was expensive, but is one of those products where you get what you pay for.



Motherboards For AMD Processors

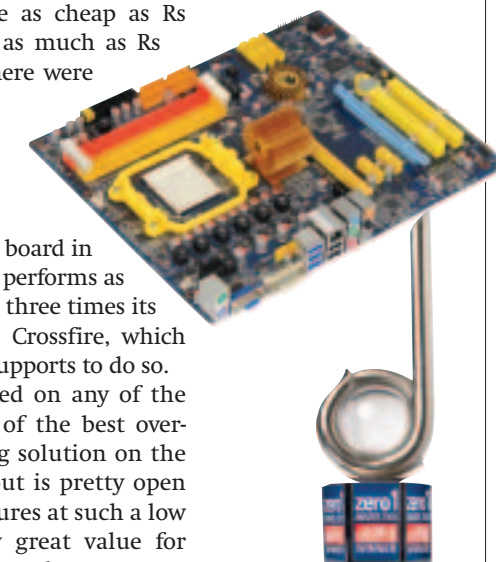
Motherboards for the AMD platform came in larger numbers. They were plenty of AMD based chipsets and even some NVIDIA chipsets. The motherboards we tested were as cheap as Rs 3,700 and prices went up to as much as Rs 15,000. Like any other test, there were the select few that stood out.

REIGNING CHAMPION

Jetway HA06

The Jetway HA06 is the perfect board in that aspect. At just Rs 5,500, it performs as good as boards that are two to three times its price. It also supports AMD's Crossfire, which makes it one of the cheapest supports to do so.

Jetway hasn't compromised on any of the features either. It has some of the best over-clocking features. The cooling solution on the board is sketchy but the layout is pretty open and spaced out. All these features at such a low price make it an absolutely great value for money motherboard. It's the only reason we give it the award for best Jetway HA06.



Flash Voyager

Cool Performance

The gold winner, the Corsair Flash Voyager, is fast, has sturdy build quality, and offers a good software bundle. To top it all, Corsair offers a 10-year warranty and on-the-spot replacement, no questions asked.

- Durable Rubber USB Drive
- Water Resistant
- Shock Resistant
- Available in 1GB, 2GB, 4GB, 8GB, 16GB Capacity
- 10 Year Warranty

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Survivor USB

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